

Year 12 Business

Autumn Term - Scheme of Work at a Glance

A ready-to-adapt 7-week map for the opening half-term of the A-Level Business course: lesson-by-lesson focus, key terms, real-company hooks, homework and the first assessment point - all on a few pages you can drop straight into your department planner.

What's inside	
The half-term at a glance	7-week overview grid (p2)
Week-by-week plan	Focus, spec, key terms, company hook, activity, misconception, homework (p3-6)
First assessment	Where to place the baseline + a quick banded guide (p6)
Key-terms glossary	Autumn-1 vocabulary + command words (p7)
Real-company hook bank	Gymshark, BrewDog, Aldi, Greggs, M&S, JD Sports (p7)

Board-neutral. Maps to **AQA 7132 section 3.1 'What is business?'** and the opening enterprise/market content of **Edexcel 9BS0 Theme 1** (1.1 meeting customer needs, 1.2 the market, 1.5 entrepreneurs and leaders). Adjust the week numbering to your own term dates. Prep time: open it, swap in your own company examples if you prefer, done.

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The half-term at a glance

Seven weeks from the first lesson to the first assessed piece. Each week is expanded on pages 3-6. Treat it as a skeleton - stretch or compress it to fit your timetable and your group.

Wk	Focus	Spec link	Big question
1	Enterprise & entrepreneurs	AQA 3.1.1 Edx 1.5	What makes someone start a business - and why do most fail?
2	Mission & objectives	AQA 3.1.1	What is a business actually for, and how do we measure success?
3	The market: mass vs niche, size, share, growth	AQA 3.3.2 Edx 1.2	How big is the prize, and who already owns it?
4	Market research & meeting customer needs	AQA 3.3.2 Edx 1.1	How do you find out what customers want before you spend?
5	Market positioning & added value	AQA 3.3.3	Why will a customer pick you over the shop next door?
6	Business forms & raising finance to start	AQA 3.1.2	Sole trader, Ltd or plc - and where does the money come from?
7	Consolidation + first assessment	3.1 whole	Can students apply the unit to a real company under timed conditions?

How to use this

One unit, one company thread. Pick a single business (Gymshark works well - students already know it) and return to it every week, so the abstract terms always land on something concrete.

Front-load the vocabulary. The page-7 glossary is the autumn-1 'must-own' list. Quiz five terms as a do-now at the start of each lesson.

Assess once, early. Week 7 places a short timed piece so you and the student both see where they are before half-term - not in December.

Make it yours. The activities and homework are deliberately generic enough to swap in your local businesses, your context and your group's level.

Weeks 1-2 - Getting started

WEEK 1	Enterprise & entrepreneurs
Spec	AQA 3.1.1 nature/purpose of business - Edexcel 1.5 entrepreneurs and leaders
Key terms	enterprise, entrepreneur, risk, reward, opportunity cost, factors of production, calculated risk, business idea
Company hook	Gymshark. Ben Francis started it in 2012 aged 19, screen-printing gym wear in his parents' garage in Birmingham while working a Pizza Hut delivery job. By FY25 the business turned over roughly £646m and sold into about 230 countries. Use it to make 'risk and reward' real, not a textbook line.
Core activity	Card sort: sort 12 traits into 'entrepreneur / not the whole story', then rank the top three that mattered for Francis. Cold-call the disagreements and make them justify.
Misconception	Enterprise is not just 'being a business' - it is the act of spotting an opportunity and taking a calculated risk to meet a need. Students drift into describing the firm instead.
Homework	Find one UK founder and write 80 words on the single biggest risk they took. Bring the figure.

WEEK 2	Mission & objectives - what a business is for
Spec	AQA 3.1.1 mission, corporate objectives, measuring success
Key terms	mission, aim, corporate objective, SMART, profit, market share, growth, survival, social/ethical objective, stakeholder
Company hook	BrewDog vs Greggs. BrewDog has long built its mission around getting other people 'as passionate about great craft beer as we are' - a clear non-financial driver - while Greggs runs about 2,600 UK shops on a value-led, high-volume objective. Same sector logic, very different objectives.
Core activity	Students write a SMART objective for a named local business, then peer-mark it against the five SMART criteria and rewrite the weakest one.
Misconception	An aim is broad and long-term; an objective is the SMART step that moves you toward it. Students treat the two words as interchangeable - separate them early.
Homework	Two objectives for a business of choice - one financial, one non-financial - each justified in one sentence.

Weeks 3-4 - The market and the customer

WEEK 3	The market: mass vs niche, size, share, growth
Spec	AQA 3.3.2 understanding markets - Edexcel 1.2 the market
Key terms	mass market, niche market, market size, market share, market growth, market value vs volume, dynamic market
Company hook	Aldi (mass) vs Gymshark's early years (niche). Aldi held about 11.3% of the UK grocery market (Kantar, March 2025) competing on price at scale; Gymshark began by serving a narrow gym-and-fitness niche online before widening. Two routes, two definitions students can actually picture.
Core activity	Calculation drill: given firm sales and total market sales, compute market share three ways; then classify five named businesses as mass or niche with a reason.
Misconception	Market size and market share are different things - share is your slice of the size. Students use the terms interchangeably and lose easy marks.
Homework	Define market size and market share in your own words, each with one UK example and a number.

WEEK 4	Market research & meeting customer needs
Spec	AQA 3.3.2 market research & data - Edexcel 1.1 meeting customer needs
Key terms	primary research, secondary research, qualitative, quantitative, sample, sample size, bias, market segmentation, customer needs
Company hook	JD Sports. Heavy marketing investment and a social following in the millions give it a constant stream of customer data to read demand. Contrast a data-rich big retailer with a start-up doing a free online survey on a £0 budget.
Core activity	Design a 6-question survey for a new product, then critique a deliberately biased sample (e.g. 'we only asked our own followers') - what is wrong with it and how would you fix it?
Misconception	Primary research is not automatically 'better' than secondary - they answer different questions; and a big sample is not automatically an unbiased one.
Homework	Collect one piece of secondary data about a market of choice (source it) and write what it tells a new entrant.

Weeks 5-6 - Standing out and getting started

WEEK 5	Market positioning & added value
Spec	AQA 3.3.3 positioning, 3.4.1 added value
Key terms	market positioning, market map, perceptual map, USP, added value, differentiation, brand, price point
Company hook	Pret a Manger. Its coffee subscription currently costs around £30 a month - a positioning and added-value move (convenience plus habit) rather than just a cheaper cup. Plot Pret, Greggs and a premium independent on a price-vs-quality map.
Core activity	Students build a market map (two axes of their choice) for one sector, place 5 real firms, then identify a 'gap in the map' and justify whether it is a real opportunity.
Misconception	Added value is not the same as profit - it is the price charged minus the cost of the bought-in inputs, before all the other costs are taken off.
Homework	One paragraph: how does a named business add value, and what would happen to its price if it stopped?

WEEK 6	Business forms & raising finance to start
Spec	AQA 3.1.2 business forms - sources of finance to start up
Key terms	sole trader, partnership, private limited company (Ltd), public limited company (plc), limited liability, unlimited liability, share capital, crowdfunding
Company hook	BrewDog 'Equity for Punks'. A real, well-known example of crowdfunding share capital from the public - a concrete way into limited liability, shares and the Ltd-to-plc journey, versus a sole trader risking personal assets.
Core activity	Decision task: a new founder picks a business form. Groups argue sole trader vs Ltd using liability, finance and control, then vote and justify their choice.
Misconception	Limited liability protects the owner's personal money, not the company itself - and a Ltd cannot sell shares to the public, only a plc can.
Homework	Table: three business forms x three columns (liability, finance, control). One real example per form.

Week 7 - Consolidation and the first assessment

WEEK 7	Pull the unit together + baseline assessment
Spec	AQA 3.1 whole section - exam/assignment technique introduced
Key terms	(revisits all autumn-1 terms) - plus first exposure to command words: calculate, explain, analyse
Company hook	M&S. The 2025 cyber-attack knocked roughly £300m off operating profit - a single rich case that touches objectives, stakeholders, risk and the external environment, so students apply the whole unit to one story.
Core activity	First half: a 25-minute timed piece (calculate market share plus a short 'explain' on why a firm chose its objective). Second half: self-mark against the banded guide below so students can see what 'application' actually looks like.
Misconception	Application means using the case's numbers and context, not just defining the term - that is the jump from Level 1 to Level 2 and where most early marks are won or lost.
Homework	Reflection: one term you have nailed, one you will revisit - and why.

Quick banded guide for the 'explain' answer	
Level 1	Defines the term or makes a general point with no link to the business in the question.
Level 2	Applies the point to this business - uses its name, its numbers or its situation.
Level 3	Develops a chain of reasoning: because X, this leads to Y, which affects Z for the firm.

Homework / retrieval bank (mix and match across the half-term)

- 1. Five-a-day key terms.** Use the page-7 glossary - students write the term, you give the definition, or flip it.
- 2. Company of the week.** Each student tracks one real UK business and feeds a fact into every lesson's hook.
- 3. Headline hunt.** Bring one business news headline and label which part of the unit it illustrates.
- 4. Numbers fluency.** Three market-share / added-value calculations a week, marked in two minutes at the start of the next lesson.

Autumn-1 key-terms glossary

The vocabulary students should own by half-term. Print it as a knowledge organiser, or chop it up for the do-now quiz.

Term	Plain-English definition
Enterprise	Spotting an opportunity and taking a calculated risk to meet a need for a reward.
Entrepreneur	The person who organises the factors of production and bears the risk of the venture.
Opportunity cost	The next best alternative given up when a choice is made.
Mission	The overarching purpose of a business - why it exists, beyond making money.
Corporate objective	A medium-term goal for the whole business (e.g. grow market share by 5%).
Market share	One firm's sales as a percentage of total market sales.
Mass vs niche	Selling to a broad market at scale vs serving a small, specific segment.
Primary research	New data collected first-hand for a specific purpose (surveys, interviews).
Added value	The difference between the price charged and the cost of the bought-in inputs.
USP	The feature that makes a product meaningfully different from rivals.
Limited liability	Owners can only lose what they invested; personal assets are protected.
Crowdfunding	Raising small amounts of capital from many people, often online.

Real-company hook bank Gymshark - garage start-up 2012 to ~£646m FY25 (risk/reward, growth) BrewDog - Equity for Punks crowdfunding (business forms, finance) Aldi - ~11.3% UK grocery share, Mar 2025 (mass market, share) Greggs - ~2,600 UK shops (value objective, scale) JD Sports - data-rich marketing (research, customers) M&S - 2025 cyber-attack ~£300m hit (risk, external environment)	Differentiation built in Support: give the glossary as a word bank for every written task; model one market-share calculation fully before students try one. Stretch: ask 'to what extent' on the company hook - push for a judgement, not just a definition; bring a second company to compare. Cover / non-specialist: each week's grid runs as-is - the activity and homework are self-contained.
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Command words to introduce alongside the vocabulary		
Calculate	Work out a figure	e.g. market share, added value, % change
Explain	Say why, with a reason	one developed point applied to the business
Analyse	Build a chain of reasoning	because X leads to Y leads to Z for the firm

Want your students to *run* a business, not just read about one?

Everything in this scheme of work - enterprise, objectives, the market, added value, business forms - students can actually do inside **The Business School**, a browser-based classroom simulation. Five teams run a company in a 60-minute session: they set prices, hire staff, take loans, handle VAT and negotiate deals, while you watch a live dashboard and the work is auto-graded. No installs - students join with a PIN.

How the free pilot works	
1. Join the waitlist	The current cohort is full - add your name at thebusiness.school for the next round.
2. We set you up	You get a class code and a one-page run sheet. No installs, nothing for IT to approve.
3. Run a 60-min session	Five teams compete; you watch the live dashboard and get an auto-graded summary.
4. Tell us what you think	No cost during the pilot - we just ask for honest teacher feedback.

More free packs like this one are on the site too.

Built by a teacher, for teachers. - thebusiness.school

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